

The WorkNest Case

Read carefully before your session. Every group reads the full story below — then turns to the questions for your assigned function. Nothing is pre-labelled for you; you'll be asked to identify entities, attributes, and business rules directly from this material.

Session Flow — 100 Minutes

Your group has 70 minutes to work through three checkpoints, followed by a 20-minute playback where every group presents. Watch the clock — each checkpoint has a specific ask, and Checkpoint 3 is what you'll actually present.

Time	Block	What must be done by the end of it
0:00–0:10 (10 min)	Framing	Read the WorkNest story as a class; get your group's function assignment (Finance / Operations / Marketing & Analytics / HR / Technology).
0:10–0:30 (20 min)	Checkpoint 1 — Diagnose	List every entity and key attribute relevant to your function's lens, and name the specific failure(s) in the story that hurt your function.
0:30–0:55 (25 min)	Checkpoint 2 — Design	Work through your function's guided questions as a group; sketch the relationships and business rules that would fix the failure(s) you named.
0:55–1:20 (25 min)	Checkpoint 3 — Synthesise	Distil your group's work into ONE clear recommendation plus a simple diagram — this is what you'll present. See “Your Deliverable” under your function.
1:20–1:40 (20 min)	Playback	Each group presents for 2–3 minutes, in the order below, followed by 30 seconds of questions from the room.

The WorkNest Story

WorkNest opened its first co-working floor three years ago, above a busy street-food market in Koramangala, with twelve hot-desks and a single glass-walled cabin for calls. Word spread fast among freelancers and small startup teams tired of paying for full offices they didn't need, and within eighteen months WorkNest had opened two more floors across the city — Indiranagar and HSR — each with its own mix of open hot-desks, reserved desks for regulars, private cabins for teams of two to four, and one meeting room that could be booked by the hour.

A hot-desk plan costs ₹4,000 a month for unlimited walk-in seating; a Dedicated Desk plan costs ₹7,500 a month for the same seat every day; a private cabin for a team of two to four rents for ₹22,000 a month. Every plan bundles free meeting-room hours — two for Hot-desk, six for Dedicated Desk, ten for a Cabin — and any hour beyond that is billed at ₹500/hour. Anyone can also walk in and pay ₹600 for a single day, meeting room billed separately if needed.

Each floor runs with a two-person front-desk team on rotating 12-hour shifts, a shared cleaning staff who circulate between the three locations, and one floor manager who also chases invoices at month-end. Every floor has twelve hot-desks, four reserved desks, three private cabins, and one meeting room — but a Tuesday lunch rush at the Koramangala floor regularly sees all twelve hot-desks and the meeting room booked out by 12:30, with staff still taking bookings by WhatsApp for a room that's already gone.

Word of mouth remains WorkNest's biggest driver of new members — most sign-ups mention a friend or colleague already working out of one of the floors — but the front desk also runs a simple Instagram page for each location and a “first day free” trial for walk-ins who look like they might convert.

Freelancers dominate the Indiranagar floor; the newer HSR floor skews toward three- and four-person startup teams renting cabins. No one currently tracks which channel actually brought in a given member, or whether trial-day visitors convert at a different rate across locations.

Front-desk staff are hired per floor and trained informally by whoever's on shift that week; there's no single record of who's been trained on the newer booking process versus who's still doing it the old way. When the Koramangala floor's senior staffer went on leave for two weeks last month, her replacement didn't know the WhatsApp-thread convention for that location and started a new thread — splitting that floor's booking history across two places for the rest of the month.

When someone wants to use a desk or a room, a staff member at the front desk notes down who's coming, which desk or room they want, and for what date and time — writing it into whichever spreadsheet or WhatsApp thread that location happens to be using that week. Some floors track bookings in a shared Google Sheet, others in a WhatsApp thread, and one location switched between the two mid-year without telling the accountant. Payments are collected either at the desk or transferred online, and someone has to remember to mark it down separately in the accounts sheet.

AS YOU READ — *What are the distinct “things” WorkNest needs to keep track of, and what would you need to know about each one?*

A Day in the Life of a Booking

Reema runs a three-person design team and has held a Dedicated Desk plan (₹7,500/month, six free meeting-room hours) at WorkNest's Koramangala floor for the past four months. On a Tuesday morning, she messages the WorkNest front-desk number to ask for the meeting room from 3 PM to 5 PM to pitch a client — the staff member checks whether the room is free at that location for that slot, and if it is, notes her name against it in the sheet.

At 3 PM, Reema and her client walk in; the receptionist recognises her, points her to the room, and doesn't bother updating anything else since her desk plan already covers her regular seat. The two meeting-room hours get counted against her six free hours for the month.

At the end of the month, WorkNest's accountant goes through every location's sheet, adds up each member's usage — desk plan cost, plus any meeting-room hours beyond what was free — and sends out an invoice. If someone wants to cancel their plan, they're expected to tell the front desk at least two weeks before their next billing date; if they don't, they get billed again automatically.

AS YOU READ — *Trace the full sequence of steps from “Reema wants a room” to “WorkNest gets paid.” Where could this process fail today — and why?*



Choose Your Lens

Before you split up: every group is chasing the same underlying question, just from a different desk — what does WorkNest need to track, and what's the specific rule that's missing that lets it fail? Finance, Operations, Marketing & Analytics, HR, and Technology will each run into a different symptom of it. Hold onto that as you work — the pattern you find in your function's questions may not be as function-specific as it first looks.

Every group works from the same WorkNest story above. Your group has been assigned one function below — read the framing, then work through your group's questions together. Facilitator: if you have more than five groups, double up on any function.

Finance

As WorkNest's finance lead, your job is to make sure every rupee owed is billed, and every rupee billed is collected — reliably, every month, across all three floors.

1. Walk through what data you'd need to generate Reema's invoice for the month described above. Which entities and attributes does that invoice depend on, and where does each currently live?
2. The case mentions two ways revenue can leak: a cancellation that isn't recorded before the next billing date, and meeting-room hours that get tracked inconsistently across floors. For each, name the business rule being broken and which ACID guarantee (Atomicity, Consistency, Isolation, Durability) failing allows it to happen.
3. If WorkNest's accountant needed to audit last month's revenue by floor, by plan type, and by member — right now, on paper — what would they have to do, and where would the numbers likely disagree?
4. What's the minimum set of tables (entities) Finance needs to trust the month-end invoice completely, and which columns (attributes) on each must never be missing or duplicated?

YOUR DELIVERABLE — A one-page sketch showing the 3–4 entities Finance depends on, the specific rule that's currently broken (name it), and the one fix you'd propose — ready to present in under 3 minutes.

Operations

As WorkNest's operations lead, your job is to make sure a desk, cabin, or meeting room is never promised to two people at once — and that staff always know what's actually free.

1. The Tuesday lunch-rush scenario describes double-booking risk at Koramangala. Trace exactly how the current process (spreadsheet or WhatsApp, whichever's in use that week) allows two staff to both believe a slot is free. Which integrity constraint — entity, referential, or domain — is missing that would prevent this?
2. List every distinct “thing” operations needs to track across the three floors (desks, cabins, rooms, bookings, locations...) and what you need to know about each to guarantee no double-booking.
3. When the senior staffer's replacement started a new WhatsApp thread mid-month, what business rule broke — and what would you tell WorkNest's founders to put in place so it never happens again?
4. Sketch the relationships (cardinality) between Desk/Cabin/Room, Booking, and Location. Where does a bridge table become necessary?

YOUR DELIVERABLE — A one-page sketch showing the entities and relationships that prevent double-booking, the specific rule that's currently broken (name it), and the one fix you'd propose — ready to present in under 3 minutes.

Marketing & Analytics

As WorkNest's marketing & analytics lead, your job is to understand who's joining, why, and what makes them stay — across all three floors, not just the one you happen to be sitting in.

1. The case says no one currently tracks which channel brought in a member, or how trial-day conversion compares across locations. What data would you need to capture — starting from the very first walk-in — to answer both questions properly?
2. Freelancers dominate one floor, startup teams another. What attributes on Member and Booking would let you segment members meaningfully by usage pattern (heavy meeting-room users vs. desk-only, frequent vs. occasional) for a targeted campaign?
3. If you wanted to run a “which floor should we open next” analysis using only WorkNest's own data, what's missing today that would make that analysis unreliable?
4. Why does scattering booking data across three separate sheets/threads make even a simple question (“which location has the highest hot-desk occupancy?”) functionally unanswerable today? Name the underlying data problem in DMBI terms.

YOUR DELIVERABLE — A one-page sketch showing the entities and attributes you'd need to segment members and track channel performance, the specific gap that's blocking this today, and the one fix you'd propose — ready to present in under 3 minutes.

HR

As WorkNest's HR lead, your job is to make sure every floor is staffed by people who know what they're doing — and that institutional knowledge doesn't walk out the door with one person on leave.

1. The case describes a staffing gap: a replacement who didn't know the booking convention for her floor. What data should HR be keeping about each staff member (training completed, floor(s) worked, shift history) that isn't mentioned as existing today?
2. If WorkNest wanted to guarantee that every shift is covered by at least one person trained on the current process, what would need to be tracked and enforced — and how does that resemble a business rule or constraint in a database sense?
3. Staff currently rotate across floors and improvise their own conventions. What entity and attributes would let HR answer “who is qualified to work which floor, doing what” reliably?
4. Where in this case does a staffing or knowledge gap cause the same kind of failure as a database integrity violation (data recorded inconsistently, or lost entirely)? Explain the parallel.

YOUR DELIVERABLE — A one-page sketch showing the entity and attributes HR needs to track staff training and coverage, the specific gap that's currently causing failures, and the one fix you'd propose — ready to present in under 3 minutes.

Technology

As WorkNest's technology lead, your job is to design the system that replaces the spreadsheets and WhatsApp threads — one that every function above can actually trust.

1. List every distinct entity mentioned across the whole case (Member, Plan, Desk, Cabin, Room, Booking, Location, Invoice, Staff...) and the key attributes each would need.
2. Identify the relationships between them, including cardinality (1:1, 1:N, M:N), and note where a bridge table is required.
3. Name at least three concrete failure modes described in the case (double-booking, split booking history, inconsistent hour-tracking, unrecorded cancellations) and map each to the DBMS concept that would prevent it (integrity constraint, transaction/ACID, single source of truth).



4. Sketch a first-draft ER diagram (boxes and relationships is enough) that would let Finance, Operations, Marketing, and HR each get reliable answers from the same underlying database.

YOUR DELIVERABLE — A first-draft ER diagram (boxes + relationships) covering all entities from the case, with the 3 failure modes you found each labelled against the DBMS concept that fixes them — ready to present in under 3 minutes.



Playback — Presenting Your Solution

20 minutes, all groups. Order: Technology presents last, since it ties every other group's fix into one picture — everyone else presents in any order the facilitator calls.

Each group's 2–3 minutes should cover:

1. The failure: one sentence naming what breaks today in your function, from the case.
2. The fix: the entities, attributes, or business rule you'd put in place — show your sketch/diagram.
3. The payoff: one sentence on what WorkNest can now trust that it couldn't before.

After each group presents, the room gets 30 seconds for one question. Facilitator keeps time — groups running over lose their own Q&A window, not the next group's presentation time.

